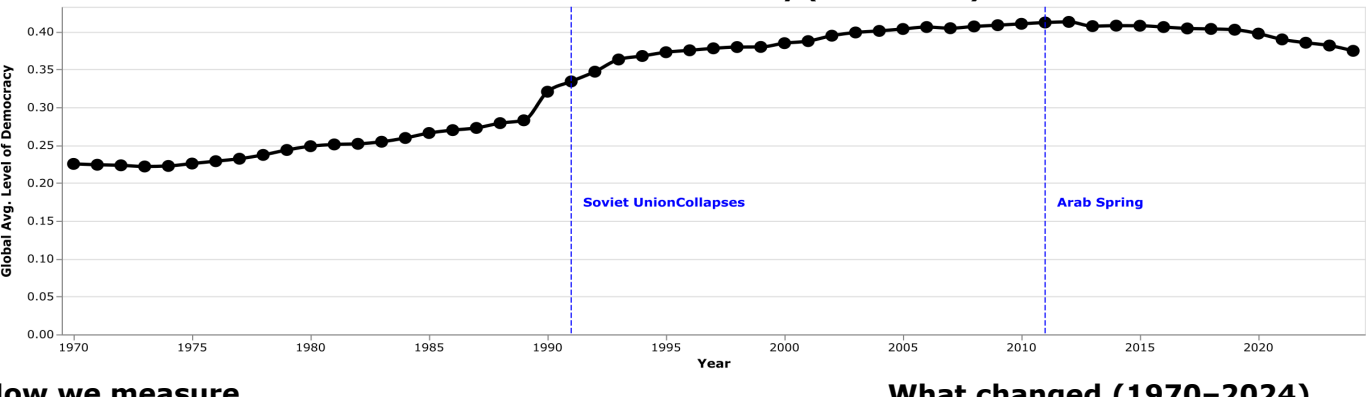


Democracy: Progress and Pillars

Since 1970, the global level of liberal democracy climbed, surged after the Cold War, peaked around 2010, and has since flattened with a slight dip. This project traces that arc and asks a simple question: what moves democracy? The following visualizations take a closer look.

The Big Picture: Democracy Over Time



How we measure

The Liberal Democracy Index (V-Dem) aggregates expert-coded indicators on elections, rights, media, rule of law, and checks on the executive. It ranges from 0–1 (higher = more liberal democracy). The chart shows the unweighted global average by year.

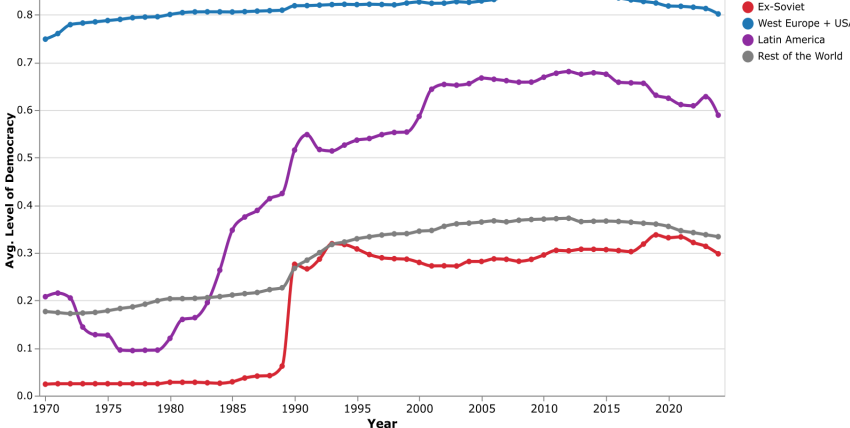


What changed (1970–2024)

Slow rise through the 1970s–80s.
Step jump 1989–93 with post-Cold War transitions.
Gradual gains in the 2000s.
Peak ~2010–12, then a flat/slight decline (mid-2010s backsliding).

After overview, I asked where the change in democracy comes from. To probe this, I grouped countries into four broad buckets and plotted their regional averages over time.

West Europe + USA: high & stable; mild softening post-2010.
Latin America: big surge mid-1980s–90s; small lift ~2000; clear decline after 2015.
Ex-Soviet: very low until 1990–92 jump, then stagnation/slip in late 2010s–20s.
Rest of World: steady gains to 2010; then flat/slight ease.



Democracy in 2024: Balance of Regimes

Full Democracy: 13 countries 7%

Competitive, free, and fair multiparty elections plus strong liberal guarantees: rule of law, judicial independence, constraints on the executive, media freedom, and protection of civil & minority rights.

Electoral Democracy: 48 countries 27%

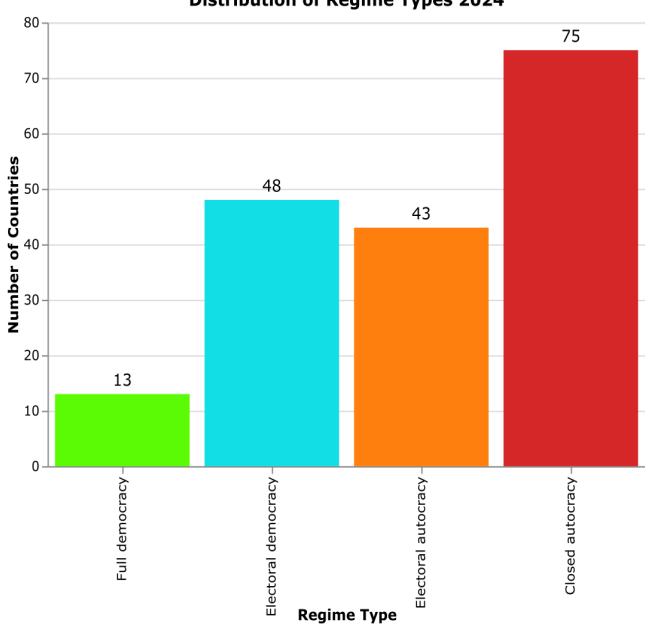
Elections meet basic standards of competitiveness, inclusiveness, and integrity, but liberal checks are weaker or uneven (courts, media, civil liberties, minority protections).

Electoral Autocracy: 43 countries 24%

Multiparty elections exist in form but not in substance with systematic bias, repression, fraud, or media capture prevent genuine contestation.

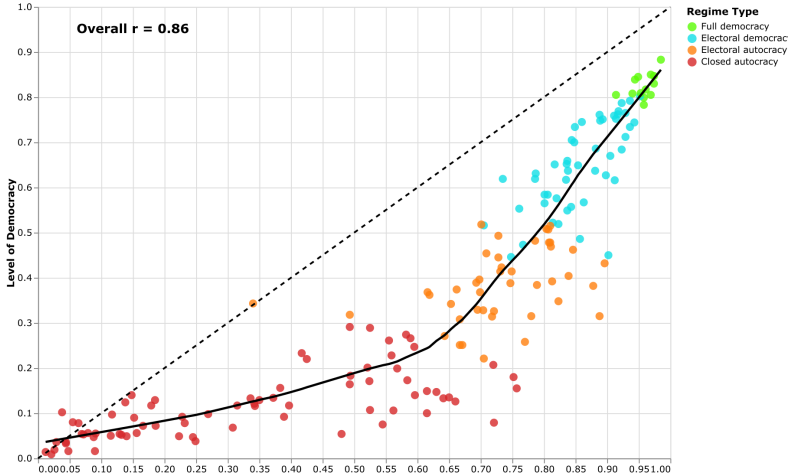
Closed Autocracy: 75 countries 42%

No meaningful multiparty competition for chief executive and legislature. Civil liberties and organization are tightly restricted.



What drives democracy?

Freedom of Expression



Definition: The extent to which people and media can speak, publish, and access information without censorship or intimidation.

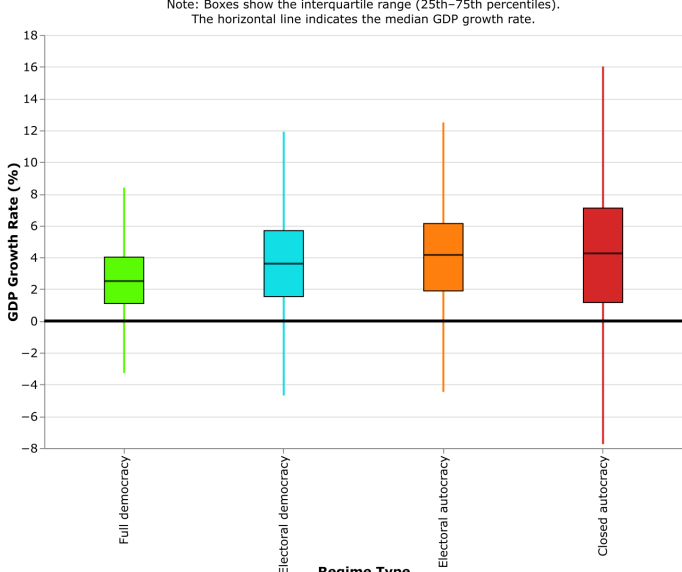
What we see: Strong, non-linear positive association with democracy ($r \approx 0.86$). The points are clustered by different regime type. More free countries are more closely clustered while non-free ones are separately widely. Its noticeable threshold around 0.65 level of freedom on expression, once countries pass it, democracy level rises steeply.

Economic of Growth

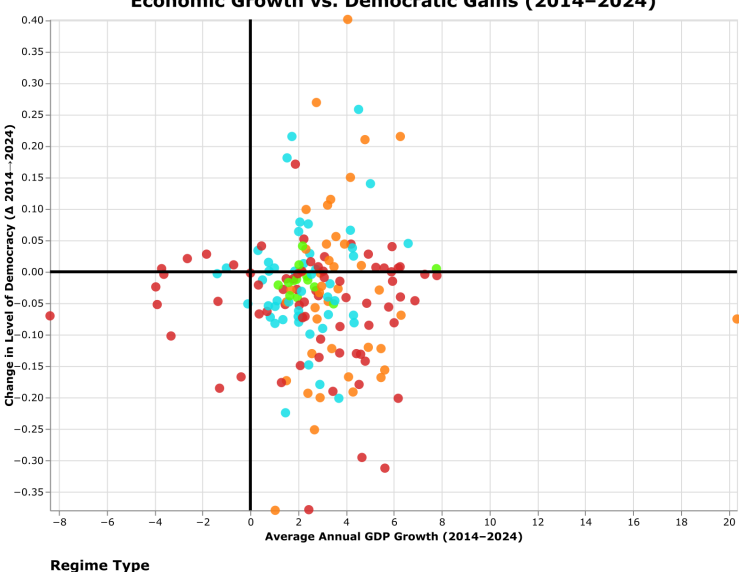
I pool all country from 1970–2024 and compare the distribution of annual real GDP growth by regime type. Median growth rates are broadly similar across regimes, while closed autocracies show a slightly higher median. The main difference is volatility: autocracies exhibit much wider dispersion, with both rapid booms and deep contractions, while democracies show tighter distributions and fewer severe downturns.

After showing how different types of regimes perform differently, I plot each country's average annual real GDP growth (2014–2024) against its change in level of democracy over the same period to test whether growth leads to democracy. The bold axis mark 0% growth and zero democratic change. These points are clustered near the origin, especially for democracies. Therefore, there is no link between short-run growth and democratic gains but other factors likely matter more.

Distribution of GDP Growth Rates by Regime Type (1970–2024)

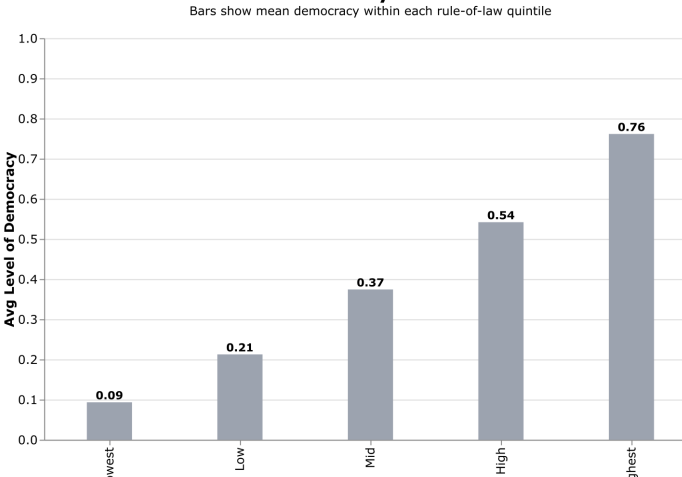


Economic Growth vs. Democratic Gains (2014–2024)



Rule of law

Level of Democracy vs. Rule of Law

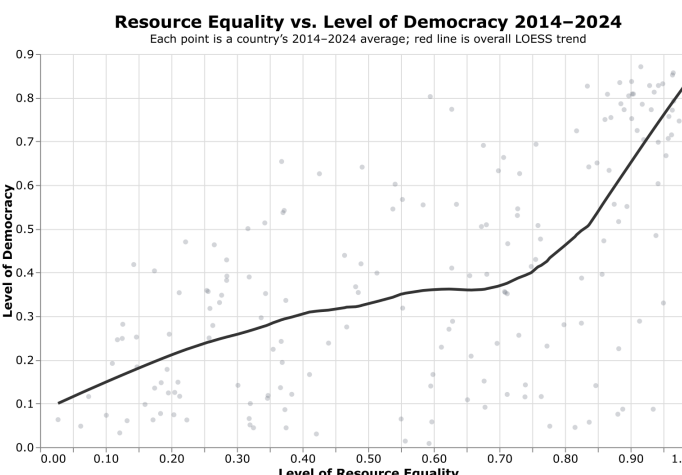


Definition: The extent to which clear, public laws are applied equally and predictably by independent courts without arbitrary power or corruption. Such concept is best thought of as an institutional stage, so I bucket countries into quintiles on the Rule of Law index (lowest → highest) rather than treating it as a single point estimate.

What we see: Each bar reports the mean level of democracy within that quintile. Stronger rule of law coincides with substantially higher democratic quality.

Resource Equality

Resource Equality vs. Level of Democracy 2014–2024

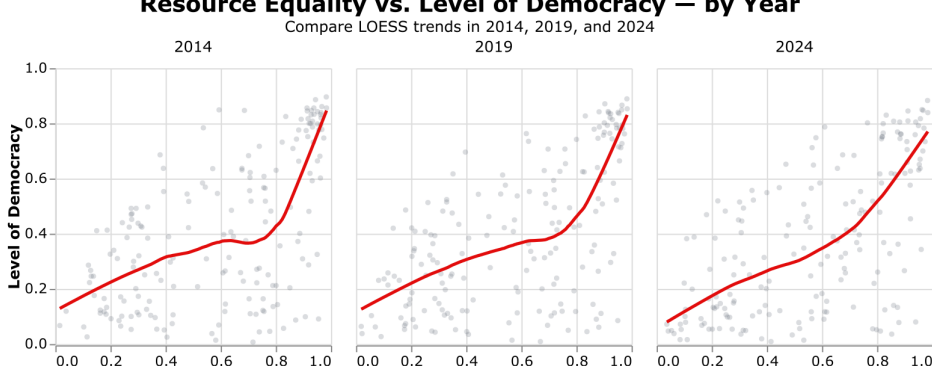


Definition: The degree to which public resources, services, and opportunities are allocated fairly across groups and regions without favoritism or elite capture. I use Equal Distribution Index (0–1; higher = more equal), averaged over 2014–2024, and plotted against the level of democracy.

What we see: The LOESS trend rises throughout: moving from low to mid equality is associated with steady gains in democratic quality, and beyond 0.85 the slope steepens and high-democracy cases cluster. Overall the relationship is clearly positive.

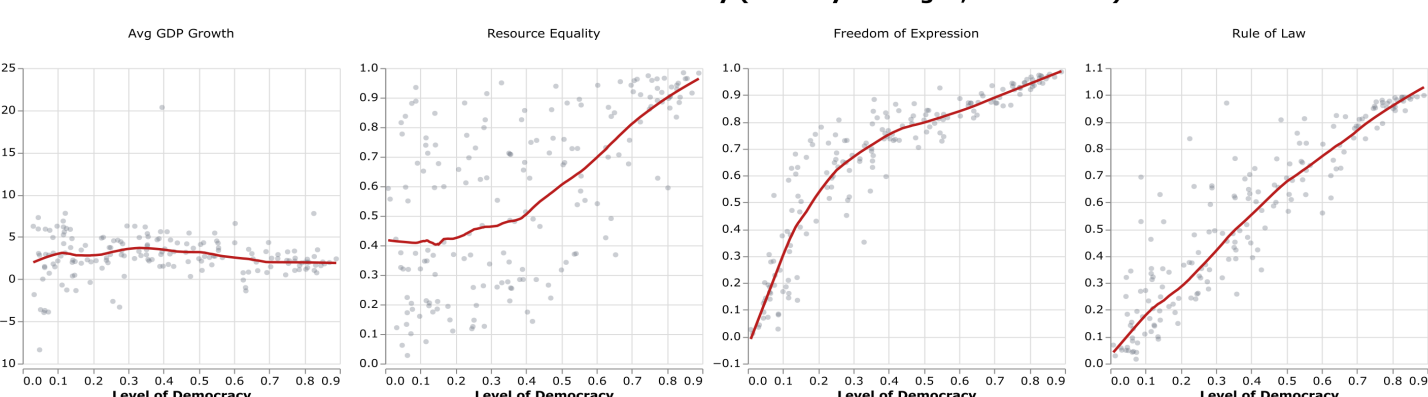
Having shown the overall association, I then check whether it holds year by year. The three small multiples (2014, 2019, 2024) plot country averages with a LOESS trend. The curve's shape is strikingly consistent across time: gradual gains from low→mid equality and a steeper rise beyond 0.8. Only 2024 sits slightly lower at mid-equality, consistent with mild democratic backsliding.

Resource Equality vs. Level of Democracy — by Year



Takeaway

Core Factors vs. Level of Democracy (Country Averages, 2014–2024)



This four-panel view places the factors side-by-side using country averages (2014–2024) with LOESS trends. GDP growth shows little relationship with democracy: flat and noisy. Resource equality rises steadily with democracy and steepens at high equality, suggesting a threshold effect. Freedom of expression exhibits a strong, nonlinear association—big democracy gains appear once expressive rights move beyond low levels, then taper at the top. Rule of law tracks democracy almost linearly across the range, the tightest, most consistent pattern of the four.

Taken together with the **long-run picture**: an upswing through the 1990s, then a plateau and mild backsliding since the mid-2010s; the evidence suggests that democracy rises and falls less with GDP booms than with **institutional openings and protections**. **Looking ahead**, trajectories hinge on shoring up core guardrails: independent courts and anticorruption, expressive freedoms and media pluralism, and fair access to state resources. Headwinds include polarization and disinformation, AI-enabled surveillance, executive overreach, external shocks, and inequality. The task is to keep rights intact in downturns and translate growth into **accountable institutions**.

Data Source: V-Dem Dataset and World Bank WDI: real GDP growth